in word AND DEED

Six alumni tell us how they have supported TUM Students and Alumni

The TUM Community is a lively network: 83,000 students and alumni all over the world support each other with motivation, advice and friendship.
Life experience is shared and the exchange between generations is kept alive; people celebrate and discuss together, and new ideas and innovative projects are born. Here, six alumni tell us how and why they get involved in the TUM Community.

You want to get involved too?
Get in touch at *alumniundcareer@tum.de*

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PROMOTING
young scientists

Design Researcher and TUM Ambassador
Prof. Dr. Amaresh Chakrabarti

"Science is capable of transcending national and cultural boundaries and brings together people to solve the problems of our world. By connecting international researchers with young academics, the *TUM Mentoring for Scientists* format also does this. Since the program exists, I have been involved as a mentor and invited my mentees to India for collaborative research. I advise them to always work hard and pursue their passions. This dramatically increases the chances of their success."

In his native India, Amaresh Chakrabarti grew up in modest circumstances. Today, he is a pioneer in Design Research in his country. He completed his Bachelor's degree in Mechanical Engineering and his Master's degree in Mechanical Systems Design in India. For his PhD in Engineering Design, he went to the University of Cambridge, UK, where he subsequently headed the Design Synthesis Team at the EPSRC Centre for Excellence in Engineering Design. At Indian Institute of Science, he founded the IdeasLab for design research and Smart Factory for manufacturing research - the first facilities of their kind in India. Since 2007, he has been Professor at the Centre for Product Design and Manufacturing, of which he is the president as well. In 2014, former TUM President Wolfgang A. Herrmann awarded him the honorary title of TUM Ambassador.

More about Amaresh Chakrabarti: *www.community.tum.de/en/amaresh-chakrabarti*

Mentoring for Scientists:
www.community.tum.de/mentoring

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GETTING INVOLVED with the Women of TUM

Architect and Entrepreneur
Niao Wu

"I especially want to infect women with my positive energy. That's why I've been involved in the Women of TUM events for years. This network specifically for female scientists, alumnae and students takes on a very important task by giving these women an international platform for exchange and mutual support in business and science. In my presentations, one thing above all is close to my heart: I want to motivate the Women of TUM to clearly communicate their goals and aspirations. In this way, we, as women, can advance gender equality by our own efforts."

Niao Wu studied Architecture in China from 2005 to 2008. She enjoyed her semester abroad at TUM so much that she decided to stay in Munich. Since then, she has built an impressive résumé in record time, with positions as an architect, a construction site manager, a business consultant and the founder of a start-up. She speaks six languages and, in the little spare time she has, enjoys attending talks on current topics like the circular economy and the digital transformation. Chinese-born Wu does all of this with impressive dynamics and genuine ease. TUM certainly benefits from the fact that Niao Wu passionately shares her success formula with others, whether as a speaker at Women of TUM events or as a mentor in the program *TUM Mentoring by Alumni for Students.*

More about Niao Wu: *www.community.tum.de/en/niao-wu*

Women of TUM:
www.community.tum.de/women

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ADVISING STUDENTS
interested in starting a company

Entrepreneur
Dr. Lars Hoffmann

"I think it is very important that the young founders at TUM can also benefit from my experience as an entrepreneur. That's why I'm involved as a mentor for TUM's EXIST Start-Up Grant. My advice focuses primarily on team dynamics, expectations, abilities and how people see their roles within the team – this is the foundation of a successful start-up, not the substantive components. Once my mentees have clarified these issues for themselves, I actively support them in the next phase. Then I help them underpin new technologies or process innovations with a business model, draw up a business plan and kick-start their financing efforts."

From 1998 to 2003, Lars Hoffmann studied Electrical Engineering and Information Technology at TUM. This was followed in 2008 by a doctorate at the Institute for Measurement Systems and Sensor Technology. At the same time, he completed his diploma in Business Engineering by distance learning. After almost two years as a business consultant at McKinsey & Company, Lars Hoffmann teamed up with three other TUM Alumni to set up a start-up called fos4X. In 2020, he sold the successful cleantech company. Since then, he has been advising and supporting companies looking to advance and implement the energy transition with digital and technological solutions.

More about Lars Hoffmann: *www.community.tum.de/en/lars-hoffmann*

Start-up Mentoring at TUM:
www.tum.de/en/innovation/entrepreneurship/for-founders-start-ups/consulting-mentoring

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INITIATING
regional networks

Business Consultant
Kai-Olaf Dammenhain

"Alongside staff and faculty on the one hand, and its students on the other, alumni are the third pillar of a university. The TUM Family thrives on the mutual support and lively exchange between all its members. In order to further strengthen the TUM Network, intensify ties to the alma mater TUM and encourage many alumni to get involved, I initiated my own alumni group for the greater Stuttgart area together with TUM Alumna Dr. Viktoria Leonhard. The new group was very well received. Since its founding in 2021, TUM Alumni from Stuttgart have been meeting regularly, sharing professional and personal experiences and supporting each other."

In 1989, Kai-Olaf Dammenhain graduated from TUM with a diploma in Mechanical Engineering. Since then, he has held one management post after another in industry and consulting. Since 2012, he has been working for the Techedge Group in Walldorf, Baden-Württemberg; currently as Managing Director beNIMBL as well as Partner in the Automotive Sector. He is the initiator of the alumni group for the greater Stuttgart area and a mentor in the program *TUM Mentoring by Alumni for Students*. He has already mentored eleven mentees. In 2012, he was awarded the TUM Pin of Honor for his far-reaching commitment to his alma mater.

More about Kai-Olaf Dammenhain: *www.community.tum.de/en/kai-olaf-dammenhain*

TUM Alumni Engagement:
www.community.tum.de/alumni

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ENCOURAGING the next generation of entrepreneurs

Entrepreneur
Catharina van Delden

"I know the challenges of the start-up phase all too well, and I know how important experienced mentors and sparring partners are. I myself benefited enormously from TUM's offers and programs during my studies and was, among other things, a mentee in the program *TUM Mentoring by Alumni for Students.* As TUM Entrepreneur of Excellence, I want to use the TUM Start-up Meet & Talks and many other events as an opportunity to give young entrepreneurs at TUM confidence in their own abilities, to support and encourage them, and to show that starting a company is a realistic path to a successful professional career."

Catharina van Delden studied Management and Technology at TUM. She completed her Bachelor's degree in 2008, followed by an Executive MBA in Innovation and Business Creation in 2010. In the same year, she set up the start-up innosabi with three other TUM Alumni. Today, the spin-off is one of the leading providers of software for idea and innovation management. In 2021, she received the honorary title of TUM Entrepreneur of Excellence. The title is awarded by President Thomas F. Hofmann to outstanding entrepreneurs at TUM who serve as role models.

More about Catharina van Delden: *www.community.tum.de/en/catharina-van-delden*

TUMentrepreneurship Expert Network:
www.tum.de/innovation/entrepreneurship/fuer-alumni-unternehmen

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MAKING IT EASIER for international students to start their careers in Germany

Information Systems Specialist
Tsvetana Marinova

"Since 2014, I have been involved as a mentor in the *TUM Mentoring by Alumni for Students* program and have already had the privilege of mentoring seven mentees. As a mentor, I would like to be a trustworthy reference for female students and international students in particular. I want to support them and find out what they really need. I want to empower them to reach all their goals and dreams. In addition to working through the very personal concerns that come with moving to a foreign country or how a woman navigates male-dominated environments, I discuss strategic forward-looking issues with my mentees. I support them in developing their skills and give advice on how to increase their chances in the German job market. All my mentees naturally get access to my own network of professional contacts. For me, that's part of good mentoring."

Tsvetana Marinova needed a fair amount of courage when she left her home country Bulgaria alone in 2007 to study in Germany. Her first few years here were far from easy. It took her a long time to feel comfortable so far away from home. After successfully completing her studies in Information Systems at TUM in 2013, she was eager to pass on her life experience to young students, especially those who, like her, come from abroad. In 2019, she joined the IT and business consulting company NTT DATA DACH, where she is currently responsible for Diversity, Equity, & Inclusion. Her responsibilities include designing an inclusive work environment in which underrepresented groups such as foreigners, women, LGBT+, and people with severe disabilities, as well as employees from different age groups, can actualize their full potential.

TUM Mentoring by Alumni for Students:
www.community.tum.de/mentoring

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